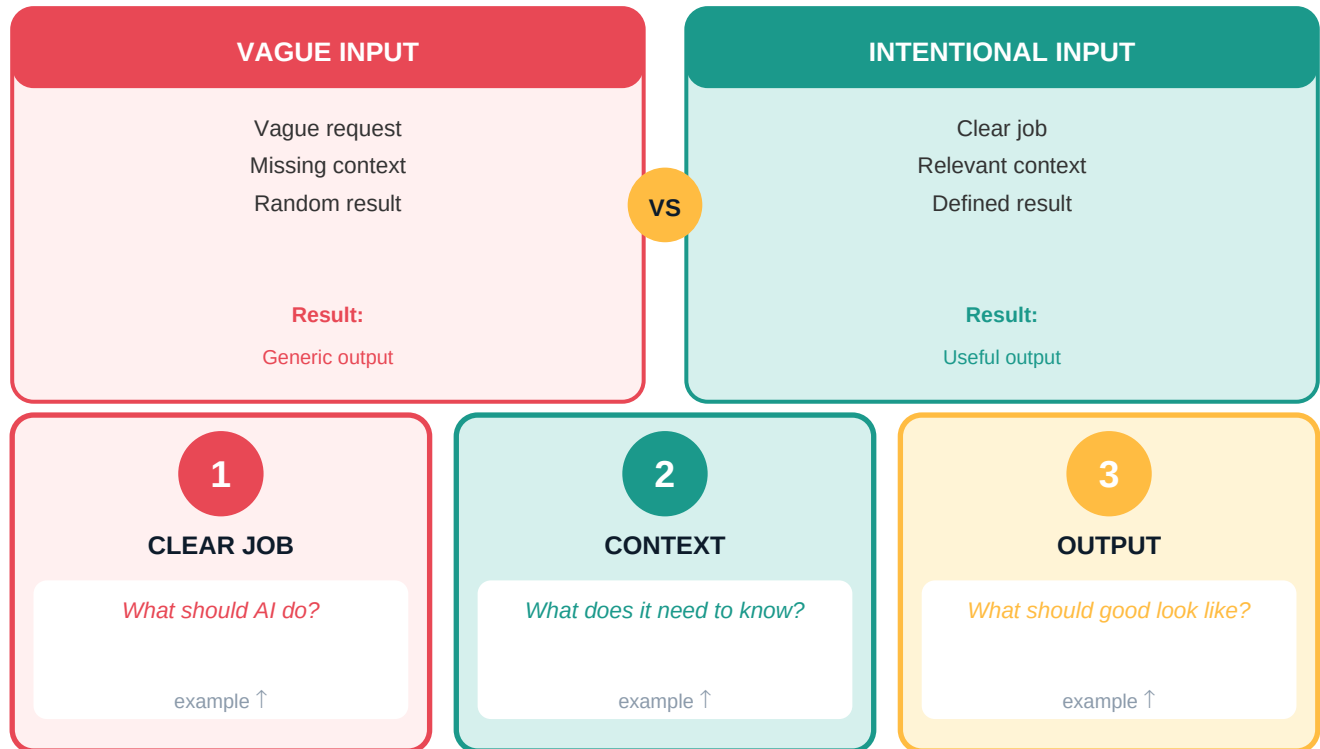


CHAPTER 1

Why AI Gives You Generic Answers (and How to Change That)



THE PROBLEM EVERYONE HAS BUT NOBODY EXPLAINS Ask ten people what frustrates them about AI and you will hear the same answers:

"It's too generic."

"It doesn't understand what I actually want."

"It's confident but wrong."

"The answer doesn't fit my situation."

"It gives me five paragraphs when I needed two sentences."

These are not problems with the AI. They are problems with the interaction.

This chapter explains why generic inputs produce generic outputs, and what specifically changes when they don't.

THE SLOT MACHINE MODEL (AND WHY IT'S WRONG) Most people approach AI the way they might approach a vending machine: insert request, press button, hope for the right thing to fall out. When it doesn't, they try slightly different words. Sometimes this works. Usually it's a matter of luck.

This approach treats AI as a slot machine. It also produces slot-machine results: random, unpredictable, and mostly disappointing.

The people who get consistently good results from AI are not luckier. They are not using secret prompts. They understand something that slot-machine users don't: AI output is shaped by input, and almost every dimension of that input is under your control.

WHY AI IS GENERIC BY DEFAULT When you send AI a vague request, "Write me a summary of this report", it has to make assumptions about everything it doesn't know:

Who is going to read this summary? How long should it be? What are the most important points to include? What should be left out? What tone is appropriate? What does the reader already know? What is the purpose of the summary?

AI will fill in all of these gaps. It will fill them in with the most statistically average answers it can construct, the kind of summary that would be acceptable to the largest number of readers in the largest number of situations. This is why AI output so often feels as though it was written for everyone and therefore fits no one particularly well.

The good news: every assumption AI makes is one you could have specified yourself. The summary would look completely different if you told AI: "This is for our CEO, who hasn't read the report and needs to decide whether to approve a £200,000 budget. She wants two paragraphs, direct language, and the headline number up front."

Same document. Same AI. Dramatically different output. The only difference is what you provided.



PART I - A DIFFERENT WAY TO THINK ABOUT AI

WHY IT WORKS AI TOOLS GENERATE TEXT BY PREDICTING WHAT WORDS SHOULD FOLLOW WHAT CAME BEFORE, BASED ON

THE THREE MOST COMMON INPUT FAILURES After looking at hundreds of AI interactions that produced poor results, three input problems appear again and again:

- THE VAGUE JOB DESCRIPTION
- "Help me with my presentation" tells AI you want a presentation.
- It doesn't tell it the topic, the audience, the desired length, your

- current draft, what help means, or what "better" would look like.
- AI has no choice but to respond generically to a generic request.
- THE MISSING CONTEXT
 - "Reply to this email" gives AI a text to work with. It doesn't tell
 - AI who sent it, what the relationship is, what a good reply should
 - accomplish, whether you need to decline or accept, how formal
 - the tone should be, or what your constraints are. AI will guess.
 - Sometimes it guesses right. Usually the first reply it produces
 - needs significant editing.
- THE WRONG ASSUMED AUDIENCE
 - "Explain compound interest" gives AI a topic. But who is asking?
 - A secondary school student? A financial professional? Someone
 - deciding whether to take out a mortgage? AI will produce an
 - explanation pitched at a generic reader, which means it may be
 - too basic, too technical, or simply beside the point for your actual
 - need.

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REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE Sarah is a marketing manager who needs to send a follow-up email to a potential agency partner after an introductory call. She types:

"Write a follow-up email after a business meeting."

AI produces a template with placeholders like [Name] and [Company] and generic phrases like "It was great connecting with you." It's technically a follow-up email. It has nothing to do with Sarah's actual situation, the tone of the meeting, what was discussed, or what the next step should be.

She then provides: who the meeting was with, what was discussed, what her specific goal for the follow-up is, and how she wants to come across. The email AI produces next is one she could send without changes.

Same AI. Same model. The variable was what she gave it.

WHAT ACTUALLY CHANGES GOOD AI OUTPUT Five inputs move the needle most consistently. They appear in greater detail throughout this book, but in brief:

- A clear job: What specifically do you want AI to do? (Not "help with", do.)
- Relevant context: What does AI need to know about your
- situation, audience, and constraints?
- Source material: What documents, notes, or data should AI

- work from?
- Output specifications: What should the result look like, length, format, tone, structure?
- Verification instructions: How should AI flag uncertainty or potential errors?



PART I - A DIFFERENT WAY TO THINK ABOUT AI

This is not a complete list. The next chapter introduces the full model. But if you apply only these five, you will notice an immediate and significant improvement.

TRY THIS TAKE A PROMPT YOU HAVE USED BEFORE THAT PRODUCED A DISAPPOINTING RESULT. WRITE IT DOWN.

Now ask yourself: What did I assume AI would know that it couldn't have known?

What context did I leave out? What does "good" actually look like for this task?

Rewrite the prompt with those gaps filled in and run both versions. Notice what changed.

WHAT THIS CHAPTER ESTABLISHED Generic inputs produce generic outputs. This is a feature, not a bug, it means every improvement you make to your input produces a corresponding improvement in output. You are not at the mercy of the AI. You are in control of the most important variable in every interaction.

The next chapter introduces a model for understanding exactly which variables are in play, and which ones matter most for any given task.

WATCH OUT MORE DETAIL IS NOT ALWAYS BETTER. ADDING IRRELEVANT INFORMATION DOESN'T IMPROVE OUTPUT, IT CAN

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